

Evidence-based strategies for ADHD

Evidence-based strategies are those that have been evaluated by researchers within school settings, and found to be effective.

Consider how you communicate

Get their attention before speaking

Eye contact, gestures, and visual or verbal prompts may be used to get student's full attention before giving instructions or speaking to them. Keep in mind that some students may not be comfortable with eye contact.

Speak clearly

Give direct instruction to provide information about the learning and associated tasks. These instructions may need to be repeated at the start of each new task and complemented with written learning intentions or activities on the board, written prompts for the student on their desk, etc.

Simplify instructions and learning

Consider breaking down big tasks into smaller ones. For example, give step-by-step written and verbal instructions with visual supports (pictures). Other strategies include providing opportunities for the student to respond, using activity sequencing, and allowing choice. It is helpful to always check their understanding before moving on to the next step or activity. For example, some students may like to demonstrate their understanding by repeating instructions or answering questions.

Vary teaching strategies

Consider using pictures, videos, PowerPoint presentations, objects, or demonstrations alongside direct instruction to explain concepts and tasks. Hands-on lessons can be very engaging.

Use computer software

Multimedia educational software on the computer or tablet may help some students focus on complex lessons, such as mathematics or reading. Interactive software where students can answer questions and receive immediate feedback are good for practising these skills. Keep in mind, establishing routines for using technology can be important for enhancing engagement.

Design and tailor inclusive activities

Schedule and alternate activities

Consider giving tasks that require higher concentration earlier in the day. Mixing high- and low- interest activities throughout the day may help keep them interested. Breaks after finishing each small task may help with their attention.

Provide choices

Giving students choices in their work can increase engagement. Consider letting them write, draw, point to cue cards, demonstrate or talk to demonstrate their learning.

Match teaching to interests and abilities

Consider what students like and can do to keep things interesting or relevant and manageable for them. As the student demonstrates skills or knowledge, provide additional learning by slowly increasing the workload or difficulty.

Give extra help

Some students may need guidance (for example, prompts, demonstrations, effective feedback) from teachers or SLSOs when learning new skills. This help can be gradually reduced as they demonstrate the skill or knowledge. They may need to be taught how to ask for help (for example, raising hands, waiting for their turn to speak). Access our [graduated guidance page](#).

Give time to practise

Provide students with lots of time to practise in different settings and with different materials to help them learn to use a skill in other situations.

Work collaboratively in groups or with buddies

This may reduce distractions when clear expectations, routines and procedures around group work are set, making it easier for them to focus. Students can practise new skills, make friends, and learn by watching others. Peers may also redirect a distracted student. Read more about [guiding students to balance their own workload when supporting a peer](#).

Consider where students are seated

Minimise potential distractions

It may be helpful to sit students with their backs facing windows, doors, corridors or other busy areas of the classroom. Classroom materials that might act as distractions such as stationery, books, colourful wall displays or 3D models could be removed when not in use.

Let students who are easily disrupted by sounds wear ear plugs or headphones while they work on individual tasks.

Consider seating

Consider sitting students near peers who can model appropriate behaviours, or close to you so you can interact with them. Short seat breaks (for example, to run an errand, touch their toes etc.) may improve focus and restlessness.

Structure classes

Establish classroom expectations

Each class should create a few short and simple classroom expectations and rules that meet the needs of the teacher and students and are aligned with school-wide expectations.

Explicitly teach behavioural expectations at the beginning of the school year and continually re-teach. Use a variety of teaching and learning strategies (such as verbal instruction with the help of pictures) to teach the expectations and rules.

Teach students the expected behaviours rather than telling them what they have done wrong. Expectations and rules should be displayed where all students can see them.

Create a consistent daily routine

Expectations and routines help a student know what is planned for the day. Consider using a timer or clock to help students learn to manage their time and routines. This can be useful if students are learning to self-monitor their behaviours too.

Access our [class schedule](#).

Provide feedback

Provide feedback

Students may respond well when their own and others' efforts and achievements are given effective individual feedback frequently. Providing timely feedback regarding appropriate behaviour and behaviour of concern is important.

Use rewarding learning or wellbeing activities

Use rewarding learning or [wellbeing activities](#) and verbal encouragement for appropriate behaviours. Students may be motivated if they can choose their rewarding learning or wellbeing activities.

Redirect students

Consider providing verbal feedback to remind students of expectations or redirecting a student who is distracted without causing embarrassment.

Use a home-school communication system

Communicate openly and often with parents or carers. Use a daily or weekly school update to monitor how a student is going with their goals. Provide support and encourage behaviours similarly in school and at home.

Teach academic skills

Teach organisation strategies explicitly

Tools such as colour-coded folders, planners or checklists can be used to help students keep track of notes, books, homework, assignments and key dates.

Ask parents or carers for support

Draw on parent or carer support where possible. When possible with parent support, students may be able to practise newly-learned skills outside the classroom.

Support students to self-manage

Set simple and clear goals

Consider letting students and families choose academic and behavioural goals. These could be short statements that describe appropriate and achievable outcomes that students understand. Check that the goals set include behaviours that can be seen and counted. For example, a goal might be handing in four items within a set time.

Teach self-reflection skills

Consider guiding students to problem solve so they can persist with school work instead of getting frustrated. For example, they can follow these steps mentally or think out loud: “What is the problem?”, “What are my options?”, “I think this is the best option”, “Am I following my plan?” and “How did I do it?”

Teach students how to self-monitor

Consider giving students a checklist of behaviours that the student would like to work on (for example, raise their hand to ask questions). Prompt the student to check off the list throughout the day. Access our [self-monitoring form](#).

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Curriculum considerations

Curriculum considerations for ADHD

All students have strengths. It is important to identify what these are to create a positive feedback cycle for the student.

Creative arts

Students with ADHD may enjoy arts and music. They may find it easier to focus in these subjects than they do in other academic areas.

Some students with ADHD are very creative and may enjoy and excel in the arts. This is great for boosting their self-confidence.

English

Some students with ADHD may find reading and comprehension manageable with additional support in written expression, spelling and using structure and logic when communicating.

It may be helpful to identify what the student needs help with. For more specific strategies for literacy, refer to tips for teaching students with [specific learning difficulty](#), including tackling underlying skills.

Other students may benefit from extra guidance organising and expressing their ideas, or they may lose track of their original ideas. Planning out ideas before writing, or using pictorial or word cues, can help them stay on track.

Consider using computer software that teaches literacy skills. Reading and typing using a computer rather than hand writing on paper may be helpful for some students.

Mathematics

Computer software may help students learn and practise numeracy skills.

Students may need to be taught how to filter out unnecessary information (for example, the problem's story) and break the important information down (for example, is it a compare, combine or change problem).

They could find word cues (for example, both red pens and blue pens are pens) and use diagrams (for example, pictures for counting).

Encourage students to try out helpful maths strategies their peers used. Ask students questions (for example, What could you do to make this easier?) to help them to think and talk out loud ways of doing problems accurately (for example, I could draw columns in multiplication problems to keep answers organised).

Refer to simplify instructions and learning, teach self-instruction skills, adapt activities, and teach academic skills.

Languages

Students with ADHD and specific learning difficulty may find learning new phonetics difficult. Refer to relevant strategies for learning phonetics in the [specific learning difficulty guide](#).

If the new language uses a non-phonetic alphabet (such as, Chinese characters) they may benefit from extra support.

Audio textbooks may allow students to focus on learning the information they need to know.

Reading, writing or speech abilities can affect the way some students with ADHD learn languages.

You may need to refer to tips for teaching students with [specific learning difficulty](#).

Personal development, health and physical education

Most students are capable in physical education. They may have varying levels of coordination and gross and fine motor skills. Refer to the [fine and gross motor page](#) for strategies to support motor skills.

Consider using peer buddies or small groups to practise sports skills. Consider assigning team members randomly so that everyone gets a chance to play.

Use clear verbal (for example, start, game over, stop) and nonverbal (for example, one whistle blow, music stops) instructions for learning skills (for example, start, stop, freeze).

Some students may like extra time to learn rules, structure and strategies in games. You may need to teach these more than once. Check understanding frequently.

Activity area boundaries should be clearly marked (for example, using cones). A separate quiet space may help some students to calm down.

Impulsive behaviours during a game may impact performance on the field. Students may make careless errors, show aggression and risk being disqualified from team sports.

Consider teaching and modelling skills that students may need during sports games. Have them practise social and problem-solving skills, managing conflict, sports skills and good sportsmanship.

Encourage appropriate behaviours, and offer feedback to students straight away when needed.

Human society and environment

Help students make personal connections to what they are learning to increase their interest in the topic.

Technology may make lessons more engaging.

Science and technology

Students may remember and engage in lessons better if they can see it in real life. Consider excursions to see science in action.

Some students with ADHD are highly creative and may enjoy and excel in Technologies.

Some students may be motivated by technology. They may find it easier to understand and complete tasks in other learning areas that integrate design and digital technologies.

Other considerations for ADHD

Safety

Some students with ADHD may display more impulsive behaviours and take extra risks that may put themselves or others in danger.

Consider using prompts and cues when necessary to prompt students to stop and calm down.

Behaviour

Some students might also show behaviours of concern. It's important to remember students are most likely trying to communicate a need or want that is not being met.

Some students may benefit from extra support to manage their emotions. Consider using some of our resources, such as the [self-monitoring form](#).

Refer to the [behaviour page](#) for more information on how to reduce behaviour of concern by supporting the student and promoting more appropriate behaviour, and our [emotions page](#) for more information about supporting a student with managing their emotions.

Classroom transitions

The time between ending a lesson (for example, putting away a book) and starting a new lesson (for example, listening to teacher or SLSO instruction, carrying out the task, and waiting for the start of lesson) may be challenging for some students.

Transitions

A student who has challenges with attention may benefit from supports when moving across education settings.

For example, it may be helpful to teach and practise organisation and homework skills, and time- and self- management skills.

For more information about supporting students with disability when transitioning to a primary or high school setting access our [transition page](#).

For students transitioning to primary school access our [school story - a school day](#) and for students transitioning to high school access our [school story - how to be organised](#).

Friendships

Some students with ADHD may need extra help in being assertive and making friends.

Sport

The [School Sport Unit](#) provides inclusive sport and physical activity opportunities and pathways for students with disability across NSW. These focus on ability, participation, enjoyment and skill development. Opportunities include gala days, Multi-Sport days, knockouts and Come-and-Try Athletics days, and are available for students with disability who learn in mainstream classrooms, support classes in mainstream schools and Schools for Specific Purposes.

Inclusive school sport programs have the potential to support a student with disability's social, emotional, mental and physical health. Watch [Lexie](#)

[External link](#)

and [Anna's](#)

[External link](#)

stories of what sport and physical activity, both at school and in their journey through the representative school sport pathway, has meant to them.

Excursions or camps

Some students may become over-excited and not respond to teacher or SLSO instructions. Others may ask lots of questions or forget about the usual expectations and instructions when placed in new environments.

Consider explaining the new structure and routine, and special rules and expectations beforehand. Check if they understand. This can relate to riding the school bus, behaving in a new place, staying in a group or not touching anything unless permission is given.

Buddies may help remind and model expected behaviours. Consider a special visual schedule for the event if it is different from the student's usual daily schedule.

Access our school story - [going on an excursion](#).

Homework

Homework may be challenging for some students. When setting homework consider what types of activities they could complete within a set time or to a set standard.

It may be helpful to teach students how to use a homework planner and to give them prompts when they need to write things down.

Some students may need to be shown how to break down projects and study into smaller tasks, and to plan their time. Teachers or SLSOs can check and sign planners.

Consider ways to support parents or carers to use consistent homework routines at home. This may be doing homework in a distraction-free area if possible at a fixed time. Parents or carers may be able to check that tasks in the planner are finished and provide encouragement and affirmation.

Access our [homework organisation support page](#).

Other co-occurring conditions

Students with ADHD may also have challenges with behaviour, learning and memory, social skills and thinking/cognition, or experience specific learning disorder (reading, writing, or mathematics), oppositional defiant disorder, or anxiety.

Refer to [understanding disability page](#) or [common needs page](#) to help support the student.